

Latécoère "Late" 521 *Lieutenant de Vaisseau Paris*

Originally conceived in 1930 for a transatlantic passenger service, the sole example of the "Late" 521 eventually appeared in 1935. Both technical and diplomatic problems delayed the inaugural flight, but finally in August 1938, the imposing 44 tonne (43 ton) flying boat, named *Lieutenant de Vaisseau Paris*, arrived in New York after

a 22 hour 48 minute flight from the Azores. Although achieving several load-to-altitude records for flying boats, war would intervene before a French transatlantic service could be established.

ENGINE 6 x 650hp Hispano-Suiza 12Nbr

WINGSPAN 161ft 9in (49.3m) **LENGTH** 103ft 9in (31.6m)

TOP SPEED 132mph (213kph) **CREW** 6

PASSENGERS 30-70



Martin Model 130 *China Clipper*

During the 1930s, Pan American Airways (PAA) was seeking new routes, particularly across the Pacific but lacked a suitable aircraft. This need was met by the Model 130. *China Clipper*, the first of three built, inaugurated the transpacific service on November 22, 1935 – initially with mail – followed by the *Philippine Clipper* and the *Hawaii Clipper*. To the public, *China Clipper* became a generic term for all Pacific flying boats.



ENGINE 4 x 950hp P&W R-1830 Twin Wasp 14-cylinder radial

WINGSPAN 130ft (39.7m) **LENGTH** 90ft 11in (27.7m)

TOP SPEED 180mph (290kph) **CREW** 6

PASSENGERS 30-70

Savoia-Marchetti S.55X

The most spectacular achievement of the S.55 took place nine years after the type's first flight. In July 1933, Italy's General Italo Balbo led a formation of 24 S.55X flying boats from Italy to the Century of Progress Exposition in Chicago in just over 48 hours. With its twin hull, the aircraft itself was far from an orthodox design, but 170 were built, and it had a long, successful career with the Italian Navy.



ENGINE 2 x 750hp Issotta-Fraschini Asso 750R

WINGSPAN 78ft 9in (24m) **LENGTH** 55ft (16.8m)

TOP SPEED 173mph (279kph) **CREW** 5-6

ARMAMENT 4 x machine guns; 1 x torpedo or 4,409lb (2,000kg) bombload

Short S.23 C-class (Empire Flying Boat)

The unprecedented order from Imperial Airways for 28 advanced giant flying boats from Short Brothers was based on a forecast income from airmail. *Canopus*, the first C-class, made its inaugural scheduled flight on 30 October 1936. The Empire Postal Service started in June 1937, when *Centurion* flew 3,500lb (1,589kg) of mail to South Africa. By October, Imperial Airways could claim to be the world's largest carrier of mail.



By 1938, Australia was nine days away for £274 (about \$1,370) return. Despite wartime losses, the last Empire boat service was flown by *Caledonia* in March 1947.

ENGINE 4 x 900hp Bristol Pegasus 9-cylinder radial

WINGSPAN 114ft (34.7m) **LENGTH** 88ft (26.8m)

TOP SPEED 200mph (322kph) **CREW** 5

PASSENGERS 17-24

Sikorsky S-38

Although not the most elegant flying boat, being variously described as "Ugly Duckling," "Flying Tadpole," and, "A collection of aeroplane parts flying in formation," the S-38 was the first commercial success for the small Sikorsky Corporation. Being amphibian, the design was very versatile, and 111 were built. Pan American operated the S-38 primarily on routes around the Caribbean.

ENGINE 2 x 415hp Pratt & Whitney Wasp C radial

WINGSPAN 71ft 10in (21.9m) **LENGTH** 40ft 4in (12.3m)

TOP SPEED 110mph (177kph) **CREW** 2

PASSENGERS 8



Sikorsky S-42

The success of the S-38 led to the larger S-40, which was the first to carry the famous Pan American "Clipper" name. The first, even larger, S-42 flew on May 29, 1934 and set innumerable long-distance records before entering service with Pan Am in August 1934.



ENGINE 4 x 700hp Pratt & Whitney Hornet 9-cylinder radial

WINGSPAN 114ft 2in (34.8m) **LENGTH** 69ft 2in (21.1m)

TOP SPEED 170mph (274kph) **CREW** Up to 5

PASSENGERS 32

Supermarine Southampton

Entering service in August 1925, the Southampton served the RAF for 12 years, a flying boat record that only the Sunderland (see page 221) would surpass. Sixty-eight were built in two versions: the Mk.I with a wooden hull, and the more numerous duralumin-hulled Mk.II. The type became famous for long-distance formation flights.

ENGINE 2 x 502hp Napier Lion V

WINGSPAN 75ft (22.9m) **LENGTH** 51ft 2in (15.6m)

TOP SPEED 108mph (174kph) **CREW** 5

ARMAMENT 3 x Lewis machine guns; 1,100lb (499kg) bombload

